

CS560 - UI/UX Design & Implementation

8-2 Short Paper: Heuristic Evaluation

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Heuristic Evaluation of News Website Home Pages

Heuristic evaluation is a usability inspection method that helps designers identify strengths and weaknesses in a user interface by comparing it against established usability principles (Nielsen, 2020). It is commonly used to evaluate how effectively websites support user goals and task completion (Garofalo, 2025). Rather than relying on private opinions, heuristic evaluations use recognized guidelines to assess how effectively a website supports users in completing their goals. For this evaluation, three major news websites were analyzed: The New York Times, Axios, and Vox. Each website was examined using usability heuristics from Nielsen's usability principles and accessibility best practices to determine how well the home pages support content discovery, navigation, and overall user experience.

The New York Times Home Page

The New York Times home page presents a traditional newspaper-style layout that contains multiple columns, featured stories, images, navigation menus, and categorized news sections. The design emphasizes credibility and provides users with access to a large amount of information directly from the home page. Major categories such as U.S. News, World News, Business, Opinion, and Culture are clearly visible at the top of the page. One usability heuristic demonstrated effectively is **Consistency and Standards** (Nielsen, 2020). The site uses familiar navigation patterns, typography, and article layouts that users expect from a professional news source. Another strong heuristic is **Recognition Rather Than Recall**, because headlines, section

labels, and visual cues help users quickly locate content without needing to remember where information is stored. Despite these strengths, the home page can feel overwhelming because of the large amount of content displayed simultaneously. This issue relates to the heuristics of **Aesthetic and Minimalist Design**. Users may experience information overload when attempting to scan the page quickly. The high density of content can make it difficult for some users, especially those with cognitive disabilities, to focus on valuable information (World Wide Web Consortium [W3C], 2023). To improve the interface, The New York Times could reduce visual clutter by increasing white space and emphasizing key stories more clearly. Creating collapsible content sections or offering personalized content filters could also help users navigate information more efficiently. These improvements would support faster content discovery and reduce cognitive load, leading to a better overall user experience.

Axios Home Page

Axios uses a modern and minimalist design approach. The home page is organized into concise news summaries, clear headlines, and simple navigation. Unlike traditional news sites, Axios focuses on presenting information in shorter formats that are easy to scan and understand quickly. The website demonstrates **Aesthetic and Minimalist Design** particularly well. Content is presented in a clean and organized format with limited distractions. Another effective heuristic is **Visibility of System Status** because users can immediately identify trending stories, breaking news, and featured content through visual hierarchy and layout organization. One usability issue is that the brief summaries may sometimes lack sufficient context for users who want deeper information before selecting an article. This relates to the heuristic of **Match Between System and the Real World**, as users may expect slightly more descriptive content when browsing news

topics. Accessibility challenges may also arise for users who rely heavily on visual distinctions because some content sections appear visually similar (W3C, 2023). An improvement would be to provide slightly more descriptive previews or article summaries while maintaining the site's clean appearance. Increasing contrast between content categories and adding stronger visual indicators for different news sections would also improve accessibility. These changes would help users evaluate content more efficiently and make informed decisions about which articles to read.

Vox Home Page

The Vox home page features a visually engaging design with bold colors, large images, and prominent headlines. The site emphasizes storytelling and editorial content while encouraging exploration of featured topics. Navigation options are displayed across the top of the page, while articles are grouped into thematic sections. The website effectively demonstrates **Flexibility and Efficiency of Use** because users can quickly access different content categories and navigate between topics. Another strong heuristic is **Recognition Rather Than Recall**, as visual cues, images, and section headings help users locate information without requiring extensive searching. However, the large visual elements and promotional content can sometimes compete for user attention. This issue relates to **Aesthetic and Minimalist Design** because the page occasionally contains more visual stimulation than necessary. Moreover, users with visual impairments may experience challenges when text is displayed over images or when color contrast is insufficient. To improve usability, Vox could simplify some visual elements and create greater separation between featured content and secondary stories. Enhancing color contrast and ensuring consistent accessibility standards throughout the site would make content

easier to read for all users. These improvements would reduce distractions while maintaining the engaging visual style that makes the website unique.

Workflow Efficiency and User Experience

The recommended improvements for all three websites focus on helping users find information more quickly and with less effort. Reducing information overload in The New York Times, providing clearer content previews on Axios, and simplifying visual competition on Vox would improve content discovery and navigation efficiency. These changes align with usability principles that emphasize clarity, consistency, and ease of use. When users can quickly identify relevant content, understand navigation options, and access information without confusion, overall satisfaction increases. Improved accessibility features also ensure that a wider range of users can successfully interact with the websites (W3C, 2023). As a result, workflow efficiency improves because users spend less time searching for information and more time engaging with meaningful content.

Conclusion

Each of the three news websites demonstrates effective usability practices while also presenting opportunities for improvement. The New York Times excels in consistency and content organization but could reduce information overload. Axios offers a clean and efficient design but could provide additional context for users. Vox delivers a visually engaging experience but would benefit from reducing visual distractions and enhancing accessibility. Applying established usability heuristics provides valuable insight into how these websites support user goals and identify practical improvements that can strengthen the overall user experience.

References:

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